

Applied Convergence

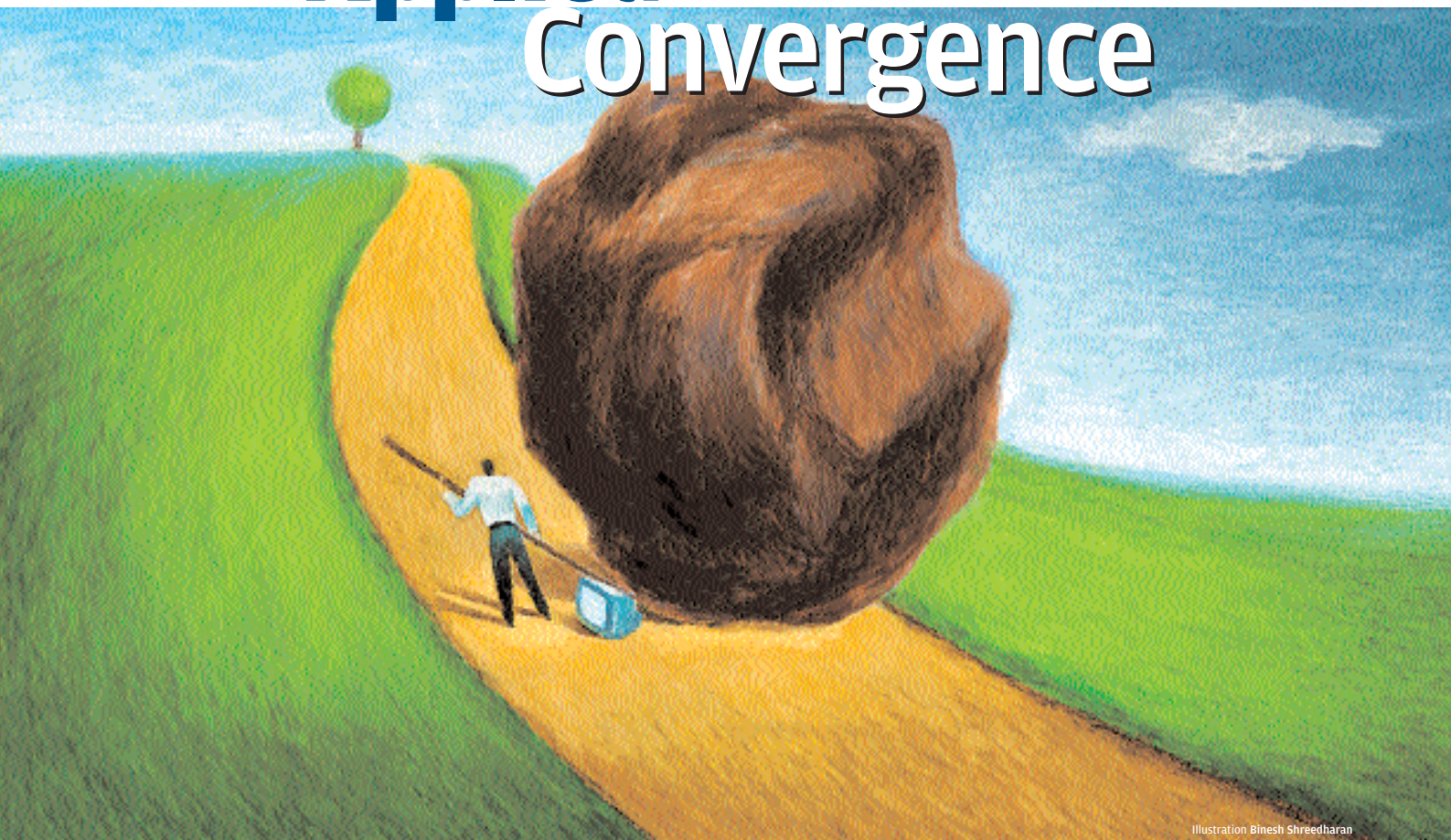


Illustration Binesh Shreedharan

Convergence is here to stay. But what type of convergence is practical? How far can we go to make it work and that too, effectively?

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Technology, in a way, needs to go back to the basics to implement the latest in cutting edge. Cryptic as that may sound, sample this: fingerprint identity could well be the most secure way to protect your data and identity. This is a classic example of convergence that could take us back to our roots in an attempt to secure us. What are some of the other practical areas that convergence could make life easier in?

Communication

Perhaps the industry that would benefit most from widespread application of convergent devices is the communications industry. There are various avenues where the communications industry could implement converged devices or technologies.

Telecommunications

Cell phones have already integrated MP3 players, cameras, PDA functionality, Web browsing capabilities and payment options. Add to this the possibility of using this as a hub for all communications, including security for your home, and you have a truly converged device. After the race to make devices smaller, vendors are back to manufactur-

ing bulkier cell phone handsets, but this time, it's not because of the lack of know-how in controlling sizes. It's just that the handsets have so much packed in to them that there is no other option!

Coming back to the handset as a security hub, it may sound far-fetched, but it's as simple as using the WAP facility on the phone. Your home could be secured with cameras that are accessible through the Internet (even on your office desktop) and there is a WAP site for this as well. All you do is log on securely and choose the room you want to view. In case of a problem (a burglary, accident, etc), you are on top of it. Even if you are not watching, you could be intimated of a problem via a text message and you could then log on to see what's going on.

Imagine this being used by doctors to monitor patients or dispense advice if they cannot be present personally. Yes, this also opens up some more security loopholes, but the benefits far outnumber the pitfalls.

Entertainment

Considering entertainment as a part of communications, you will no longer need to buy a newspaper. In an ideal world, this could also help save trees and cut down on the production of paper. But more practically, you could just download a page (or a news article) from your favourite site (or news-